Quality and Safety Pharmacy Program

PROGRAM RULES

The following Program Rules apply to pharmacies with an application, assessment or Accreditation Expiry Date, on or after Thursday 1 October 2026. If your accreditation occurs before this date, please refer to the previous QCPP Rules on the QSPP Website. This document should be read in conjunction with Program Materials.

Important terms and expressions are defined at the end of this document.

Pharmacy Conduct

Rule 1

You and your staff will act in good faith and in a respectful and courteous manner in all dealings with authorised QSPP personnel (including but not limited to the authorised assessor, any authorised attendee, and the administrators of the QSPP). Failure to do so may result in the application of a sanction in accordance with the Program Rules.

Accreditation

Rule 2

Accreditation can only be issued if the Program Materials are accepted by the Pharmacy Owner. These materials can be reviewed and accepted at the QSPP Knowledge Hub. Alternatively, if you require a paper or electronic copy of these materials, please email support@qspp.com

The Pharmacy Owner will be granted access to the QSPP Customer portal to facilitate QSPP Accreditation.

Rule 3

The Accreditation Expiry Date may be permanently changed:

a) by agreement between the owner and QSPP
b) unilaterally by QSPP, giving the Pharmacy Owner reasonable notice.

Assessment bookings

Rule 4

Pharmacies requesting to undertake an initial Assessment (whether because the Pharmacy has not previously been QSPP accredited or because its QSPP accreditation has expired, been lapsed, or revoked) are required to pay their first Annual Invoice prior to booking an initial Assessment. Once this invoice has been paid, the Pharmacy will be granted access to the QSPP Customer Portal.

Rule 5

All Re-accreditation Assessments must occur within three calendar months of their Accreditation Expiry Date unless otherwise agreed between QSPP and the pharmacy owner.

Rule 6

The Pharmacy will be allocated an Assessment Date by the assessment services provider.

Rule 7

Where a Pharmacy Owner fails to schedule an onsite Accreditation Assessment within the time frame stipulated in Rule 10, the owner must make a request for Rescheduling an Assessment in writing prior to the Accreditation Expiry Date. The request will only be granted in exceptional circumstances (in QSPP's opinion, acting reasonably). A written request describing the exceptional circumstances must be submitted to QSPP for consideration at the time of, and with the application for Re-Accreditation. Requests for extension of time will be assessed on their merits and the decision to grant the extension is entirely at the discretion of the QSPP. If any extension of time is given, the QSPP may impose such conditions as it deems appropriate in the circumstances.

Rule 8

A Mid-Cycle Review will be undertaken as a remote assessment to check-in and assess ongoing compliance with the program. This assessment is to be scheduled within the second year of the accreditation cycle (month 15 – month 21 of the 36-month accreditation cycle). Any requests to reschedule assessments are to occur within the time frame stipulated in Rule 10.

QSPP Assessor

Rule 9

The Pharmacy will be allocated an approved and independent QSPP Assessor by the QSPP's assessment services provider. A change of assessor can be requested by the Pharmacy and may be granted by QSPP if, in QSPP's opinion, a real or perceived conflict of interest is demonstrated by the Pharmacy.

Any alternate Assessor will be allocated through the same allocation process.

Rule 10

Pharmacies will be advised of their Assessment Date with reasonable notice. If QSPP incurs any expense because the Pharmacy is unable to accommodate the date and time proposed by the assessment scheduling team, the additional expense will be payable by and invoiced to the Pharmacy as an 'Additional Assessment Expenses Invoice' expense after the assessment.

If an assessment is cancelled and/or rescheduled within ten (10) business days of the Assessment Date, or the virtual/remote component of the assessment is cancelled and/or rescheduled within two (2) business days of the scheduled time for the virtual/remote component, then the full cost of one (1) assessment plus any travel expenses incurred to that point in time, will be paid by and invoiced to the Pharmacy, and a rescheduled assessment, where deemed appropriate, may be arranged.

Accreditation assessments

Rule 11

Assessments will be conducted using a compliant/non-compliant methodology. A Pharmacy is assessed as compliant where its knowledge, skills, practices etc, meet the standards specified in AS85000:2024 and non-compliant where it does not.

Rule 12

The Pharmacy must provide any information or assistance, and/or access to any part of the Pharmacy's premises, which is reasonably requested by the Assessor.

Any material, information, document, and/or evidence (whether in electronic or physical form) which is represented to the Assessor as serving a role or function or being a specified thing must bona fide serve that role or function and/or actually be the specified thing.

Rule 13

A Pharmacy Owner must be physically present at the Pharmacy premises for the duration of any scheduled onsite QSPP Assessment, unless otherwise agreed in writing by QSPP. Failure of an owner to be present may result in the rescheduling of the Assessment and the Pharmacy being liable for any associated costs in accordance with these Program Rules.

Rule 14

You must ensure that during the QSPP assessment, the QSPP assessor has access to and is able to sight (and, at their discretion, copy or record) evidence demonstrating compliance with AS85000:2024 and the QSPP User Assessment Guide.

You must ensure that any document or record provided to the QSPP assessor as evidence of compliance is what you purport it to be, is true and correct, and is not in any way misleading or deceptive. For some requirements, the QSPP assessor may need to sight evidence which includes business or personal information. You must redact 'commercial in confidence' or 'personal information' if it is not relevant to the QSPP assessment. Redacting key elements of a document is an important step in protecting personal data such as names, date of birth, Medicare numbers etc., on the basis that any redacted information cannot and will not be considered for assessment purposes.

Rule 15

If a sub domain within the QSPP User Assessment Guide is deemed to not be applicable to a particular pharmacy's business operations, it will not be assessed.

Rule 16

All aspects of the operations of a Pharmacy (including the pharmacy premises) are subject to assessment against AS85000:2024.

For the avoidance of doubt, a QSPP assessment may include, but is not limited to:

a) all services offered by the Pharmacy
b) all products (including product ranges) offered by the pharmacy business, (including products offered online), and
c) all marketing and promotion activities undertaken by or on behalf of the pharmacy business, including social media and website material.

In instances where non-pharmacy operations are occurring inside the Pharmacy premises, and those non-pharmacy operations are subject to the oversight or accreditation of a non-pharmacy regulator or accreditor, and are able to provide certification of compliance or accreditation, the business processes, requirements and standards relevant to only those non-pharmacy operations may be excluded from the assessment against AS85000:2024.

Rule 17

If a Pharmacy declares that a separate business is trading in stock or services in an area that is adjoining the Pharmacy, for the purpose of seeking and maintaining QSPP accreditation the Pharmacy must ensure:

a) the separate business provides independent customer access from a common public area
b) there is a floor to ceiling wall for at least 50 percent of the common boundary between the Pharmacy and the adjoining business
c) the remainder of the common boundary is capable of being closed and locked so no access from one business to the other is possible
d) the pharmacy and any adjoining business operate separate point of sale systems
e) pharmacy staff are identifiable as being unrelated to any adjoining business, and
f) stock from the separate business cannot be purchased in the pharmacy.

Rule 18

Where all of the requirements specified in Rule 17 are not met, the space occupied by all adjoining entities and all aspects of the operations (including staffing) of adjoining entities will be considered as part of the Pharmacy and be subjected to the QSPP assessment.

Rule 19

During an assessment an authorised attendee representing QSPP may accompany the assessor. The role of the authorised attendee is to observe and/or validate the assessment approach used by the assessor. Any costs associated with attendance of the authorised attendee will be borne by QSPP. The Pharmacy will receive advance notice that there will be an additional attendee attending their pharmacy assessment.

Rule 20

The QSPP User Assessment Guide provides guidance and examples of the sort of practical evidence required to be provided at the time of assessment. The assessor must be able to sight the evidence required during the assessment.

Rule 21

In some circumstances, the assessor will require evidence which may contain 'commercial in confidence' or 'personal' information. Assessors are required to satisfy themselves that any evidence provided is a genuine document, however a detailed investigation of the data contained within it is not required. Pharmacies may choose to mask 'commercial in confidence' and must redact 'personal information' from evidence provided for review in an assessment in circumstances where that information is not relevant to the assessment.

Rule 22

Program Materials must be demonstrably accessible to all Pharmacy staff at each assessment.

Rule 23

The outcome of any previous assessment(s), sanction(s) or investigation(s) in respect of the pharmacy business (including any related materials such as reports and correspondence relating to the pharmacy business), may be provided to the QSPP endorsed assessor for verification or review for the purposes of any current or future QSPP assessment.

Additional assessments

Rule 24

Once Accredited, the pharmacy business may be required to participate in additional mandatory assessments. All additional assessments are conducted by an approved and independent QSPP Assessor.

Rule 25

Additional Assessments may be conducted:

a) where QSPP imposes a sanction in accordance with Rule 44 that requires full or partial reassessment
b) where QSPP reasonably considers that the Pharmacy or pharmacy owner may be in breach of the Program Materials or does not comply with the AS85000:2024.
c) if the Pharmacy has changed ownership or control within the preceding 6 months
d) in the circumstances contemplated by Rule 26, or
e) in any other event or circumstances that in the QSPP's reasonable discretion triggers the requirement for an Additional Assessment.

Rule 26

Additional Assessments include the following:

a) supplementary assessment – may consist of either onsite or virtual assessment. A maximum of two random assessments may be conducted in any calendar year
b) unannounced assessment (without notice)
c) Expansion of Services assessment if QSPP is notified, or believes, that the pharmacy business has expanded their service offering which is relevant to their QSPP accreditation
d) Mandatory Re-Assessment – consists of a full onsite assessment for pharmacies who do not meet compliance requirements during a scheduled Assessment.

Rule 27

Expansion of Services Assessment: Where a Pharmacy seeks to provide an additional category of service to their business model between accreditation assessments, they must apply for an Expansion of Services Assessment using the form available on the QSPP Customer Portal. This is an additional assessment that will incur a fee which must be paid prior to service category accreditation being awarded. Any Expansion of Services Assessment request will be terminated if the invoice is overdue (see Rule 37 for payment terms).

Where an accredited pharmacy business is found to have been offering or advertising a service which is not within the service category for which they are QSPP accredited, a sanction may be issued (in accordance with Rule 42).

Corrective Actions

Rule 28

The pharmacy business has 30 days from the interim report date to remediate any Non-Conformances identified during an assessment. Should additional time be required, an extension must be requested via the QSPP Customer Portal prior to the existing due date, demonstrating exceptional circumstances that necessitate the request.

These applications will be assessed on their merits and the decision to grant the extension is entirely at the discretion of the QSPP. If any extension of time is given, QSPP may impose such conditions as it deems appropriate in the circumstances.

Rule 29

If Corrective Actions to address Non-Conformances are not completed by the Pharmacy and verified to the satisfaction of the Assessor (in writing) in the specified timeframe, the Pharmacy will be deemed to have:

a) not met the requirements of Accreditation in the case of an initiating Pharmacy and Accreditation will be denied, or
b) not met the requirements for Re-Accreditation in the case of a currently Accredited Pharmacy and their Accreditation will lapse.

Rule 30

The Pharmacy is liable for any costs associated with any additional assessment activity required to verify evidence required to address the Non-Conformances.

Rule 31

Evidence provided to address Non-Conformances must be in de-identified format. The authorised assessor will not consider evidence containing identifiable personal information and any evidence received containing personal information will be deleted immediately.

Rule 32

A Minor Non-Conformance may be closed at the time of an onsite assessment but will be recorded as an identified Non-Conformance in the assessment report, together with the evidence provided to remediate the issue.

Rule 33

A Major Non-Conformance cannot be closed while the assessor is on site at the assessment and will require the pharmacy business to provide via the QSPP Customer Portal:

a) a root cause analysis of factors leading to the identified Non-Conformance
b) steps taken to ensure the Non-Conformance will not recur, together with any additional evidence identified as required to address the specific issue.

Rule 34

If the same Non-Conformance is identified at two consecutive assessments this may result in a Mandatory Re-Assessment being issued pending investigation by QSPP. Immediate remediation may also be required.

Revoking or suspending accreditation

Rule 35

The Pharmacy owner's QSPP accreditation may lapse, be revoked or be suspended by QSPP if:

a) The pharmacy owner fails to pay any accreditation fees or other moneys payable to QSPP as they fall due
b) The pharmacy owner otherwise fails to comply with any of the Program Materials including the QSPP Terms and Conditions and these Program Rules
c) The Accredited Pharmacy does not comply with AS85000:2024 and the QSPP User Assessment Guide at any time during the accreditation period, or
d) The Pharmacy owner engages in conduct in connection with the carrying on of the business of a community pharmacy or the practice of pharmacy which in the reasonable opinion of QSPP is likely to bring accredited pharmacies or QSPP into disrepute.

Fees

Rule 36

Fees are payable at the following stages of accreditation and reaccreditation (as applicable to the pharmacy business):

Invoice description	When payable
Administration Invoice	A fee to recover administrative costs of QSPP delivering services additional to the onsite assessment [Rule 43]
Assessment Cancellation	Fee incurred if assessment is cancelled within 10 business days of assessment date or failure to complete virtual/remote component of assessment [Rule 10]
Assessment Reschedule	The annual invoice required for maintenance of accreditation. Initial or return to program pharmacies are required to pay this invoice prior to the QSPP assessment.
Annual Invoice	The annual invoice required for maintenance of accreditation. Initial or return to program pharmacies are required to pay this invoice prior to the QSPP assessment
Additional Assessment Expenses Invoice	Will be issued where the Pharmacy has not accepted the most cost-effective assessment date or has cancelled an assessment and non-refundable assessment costs had already been incurred [Rule 10]
Expansion of Services Invoice	Will be issued where a Pharmacy requests to have evidence of an additional professional service category to be assessed out of cycle in order to add that expanded service category to their accreditation [Referred to in Rule 27]
Verification of Corrective Action	When an onsite visit of an authorised assessor is required to verify that a Non-Conformance has been resolved [Referred to in Rule 30]

For details of QSPP fees please refer to Fee Schedule on the QSPP website.

Rule 37

QSPP invoices are issued on strict 28-day terms.

Feedback and complaints

Rule 38

A Customer Satisfaction Survey will be shared with pharmacies once the interim report is issued, and pharmacies are encouraged to provide feedback. Additionally, QSPP welcomes feedback on any aspect of the Pharmacy's experience with QSPP, including complaints, concerns, compliments or suggestions. If you

would like to provide feedback to QSPP at any time please complete the QSPP Feedback Form on our website or send a detailed email to support@qspp.com.

Rule 39

Should a Pharmacy have concerns about an assessor and/or the assessment process as applied during a specific assessment, a formal complaint detailing the nature of the complaint and resolution sought should be lodged in writing via email to support@qspp.com or using the complaint form available on the QSPP Customer Portal.

All complaints will be thoroughly investigated and a written response provided to the complainant. The Pharmacy must support the investigation and provide a timely response to any requests for further information that it receives to allow QSPP to assess the complaint appropriately.

Rule 40

Complaints lodged about an Accredited Pharmacy may be investigated at the discretion of QSPP.

Rule 41

All complaints lodged in relation to a Pharmacy meeting accreditation requirements will be investigated by QSPP and a written response provided to the complainant. The Pharmacy must support the investigation and provide a timely response to any requests for further information that it receives to allow QSPP to assess the complaint appropriately. The details of a complaint or resulting investigation by QSPP may result in a sanction being issued and be referred to appropriate authorities.

Sanctions

Rule 42

QSPP may investigate any matter which it considers may breach the Program Materials, or any other matter which may affect the Pharmacy's QSPP accreditation or the QSPP ,and may apply any sanctions it concludes are appropriate under the Sanctions Management Policy (available on the QSPP Knowledge Hub).

Rule 43

The Pharmacy is liable for all of QSPP's costs and expenses incurred in connection with a sanction, including in respect of undertaking any investigations, reviews and assessments that QSPP deems necessary.

Rule 44

Failure to comply with a sanction within the designated time frame may result in a higher sanction being applied.

Review of Decision

Rule 45

Pharmacy Owners have a right to appeal a Reviewable Decision on the grounds that the decision was not made in accordance with the applicable rules and policies of QSPP.

A Reviewable Decision is any decisions of QSPP which affects the Pharmacy and is in relation to:

a) QSPP assessment outcomes, including Non-Conformances
b) Revocation or suspension of accreditation, and
c) Outcomes of investigations or assessments, including sanctions.

Rule 46

Any request for a review is to be made in writing via the QSPP Customer Portal or to support@qspp.com.

Rule 47

All appeals will be considered by the relevant authority as outlined in the Procedural Fairness and Impartiality Policy.

Website and Portal

Rule 48

You are responsible for the use of the QSPP website, QSPP Knowledge Hub and QSPP Customer Portal and all other QSPP intellectual property by any person (including any agent or employee of the Pharmacy) who you allow to access the website, Knowledge Hub or portal. You must ensure that all QSPP intellectual property is protected at all times from unauthorised access or use via the access and usage rights which have been granted to you.

We will give you a unique user ID and password for use of the QSPP Customer Portal and Knowledge Hub and may at any time revoke such user ID or password if we believe that the security of that user ID or password has, or may have been, compromised.

You must immediately inform QSPP if you suspect that the security of a user ID or password has, or may have been, compromised, or there has been unauthorised access to the QSPP Customer Portal or Knowledge Hub.

You must not, and must ensure that your authorised users do not, disclose their user ID or passwords to any other person (including by training and regularly reminding authorised users not to make such disclosures).

Promoting Accreditation

Rule 49

Marketing and/or banner groups may only use the QSPP Brand on group branded collateral, both printed and electronic and including webpages, where 100 percent of the pharmacies within the banner group are QSPP accredited. Pharmacies joining the marketing group have a period of six months to become QSPP accredited without affecting the use of the QSPP Brand by the banner group as a whole.

General

Rule 50

Headings are inserted for convenience only and do not affect the interpretation of these Program Rules.

Rule 51

Where the context permits, words or expressions that are defined in the QSPP Terms and Conditions have the same meaning when used in these Program Rules.

For the purposes of these Program Rules:

Term	Definition
Accreditation Expiry Date	Date by which the Pharmacy must be re-accredited to maintain accreditation.
Annual Invoice	Means the annual invoice issued to Pharmacies which is required to be paid within the payment terms to maintain QSPP accreditation.
Accreditation Period	The period of the accreditation cycle, in this instance 3 years.
Agreement	The Registration Form, these Terms and Conditions, the Program Rules, the Policies, the Annual Attestation Statement and AS85000:2024 - Australian Community Pharmacy Standard (AS85000:2024) and to the extent of any inconsistency, the documents will take precedence in that order.
Attestation Statement	A formal document the Pharmacy submits annually to QSPP to confirm compliance with AS85000:2024 Australian Community Pharmacy Standard.

Assessment	An assessment of the Pharmacy's business, operations and practices against AS85000:2024 by an assessor who has been appointed and authorised by QSPP for that purpose. The assessment aims to identify and address any gaps in quality and safety systems, supporting continuous improvement in patient care.
Corrective Action	The action or actions required to resolve a Non-Conformance.
Mandatory Re-Assessment	A mandatory additional onsite assessment when Non-Conformances identified during an assessment or review require priority re-testing.
Mid-Cycle Review	A virtual review conducted remotely between months 13 and 24 of the 36-month accreditation cycle to assess ongoing compliance.
Non-Conformance	A Non-Conformance is any deviation from the requirements specified in the Quality and Safety Program or the AS85000:2024 that indicates a pharmacy's processes, documentation, or practices are not meeting the specified criteria.
Pharmacy	Pharmacy business identified in the Registration Form and, as the context requires, its business and related operations.
Pharmacy Owner	A registered pharmacist who holds significant control and financial interest in a pharmacy business, taking responsibility for its overall management, policies, and compliance with regulations.
Program Materials	This includes Terms & Conditions, Program Rules, QSPP User Assessment Guide, and any other policy and procedure materials listed on the QSPP website.
QC2020 Program Rules	The set of rules, obligations, and requirements that govern participation in the QC2020 Program (Version 1.3, October 2022).
QSPP	Quality and Safety Pharmacy Program.
QSPP Policies	The documented policies developed for QSPP.
QSPP Program Rules	The set of rules, obligations, and requirements that govern participation in the Quality and Safety Pharmacy Program.
QSPP Terms & Conditions	The terms and conditions that govern participation in the Quality and Safety Program.
QSPP User Assessment Guide	This explains each element of the Standard in details and outlines evidence and actions required by the Pharmacy to meet compliance with the Standard.
Re-Accreditation Assessment	Refers to the onsite assessment conducted at the end of a pharmacy's accreditation period—typically every three years—to determine whether the pharmacy continues to meet the compliance with AS85000:2024 Australian Community Pharmacy Standard. Successful completion of a re-accreditation assessment is necessary for a pharmacy to maintain its accredited status and continue participation in the program.
Registration Form	The form completed by pharmacies with respect to registering with the Quality and Safety Pharmacy Program.
Sanction	A penalty or corrective action imposed on a community pharmacy for Non-Conformance or breach of program rules.
Transition Assessment	A virtual review will be conducted remotely during months 1-18 of the 36-month accreditation cycle. This assessment differs from a Mid-Cycle Review as it serves to introduce pharmacies to QSPP who are not due for a full Initial or Re-Accreditation Assessment.

The Pharmacy Guild of Australia	The Pharmacy Guild of Australia is a member-based organisation that represents community pharmacy owners in Australia. It advocates on behalf of its members, provides professional support, and works to ensure the viability and sustainability of community pharmacies.

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